

Question 30 · Unit 2 · 8 Marks

Apply the concept of HRD subsystems to propose a development path for an employee identified as having future leadership potential.

Introduction

Do not propose only ‘send the person on an MBA’ or ‘promote immediately’. Leadership potential means the person may be able to take larger people and decision responsibilities in future — it is not a certificate that they are already a leader. Apply all major HRD subsystems over two to four years: potential validation, career planning, performance appraisal, training and education, on-the-job stretch, mentoring, feedback and counselling.

Detailed points

- 1. Validate potential fairly (potential appraisal subsystem).** Use more than one source: current results, behaviour with people, assessment centre or work sample, views of more than one senior. Wrong labels destroy careers and create politics. Tell the employee honestly what was seen as potential and what is still a risk (for example, impatience).
- 2. Draw a career map together (career planning).** Discuss possible roles in three to five years (team leader, project manager, branch head) and the employee’s own aspirations. Identify competency gaps versus those roles. Career planning notes say individual and organisational goals must be integrated. Write a path with more than one possible fork, not a single promised throne.
- 3. Keep present performance strong (performance appraisal).** Potential is not a holiday from the current job. Appraisal should include both results and leadership behaviours: coaching juniors, decision quality, integrity, collaboration. Weak present performance with a ‘high potential’ tag will not be believed by others.
- 4. Stretch experiences — the main developer.** Job rotation, leading a project, deputy to a manager, cross-functional task force, handling a difficult customer segment. Potential grows mostly through carefully supported difficult work, not through classroom only. Each stretch should have a learning goal.
- 5. Training and education mix.** Conceptual inputs (how the business makes money, basics of finance, people management) plus skill workshops (feedback, conflict, planning). Time them just before or during stretch roles so that transfer is possible.
- 6. Mentor plus counselling.** A senior mentor who is not always the direct boss. Counselling for transition stress, self-doubt, or derailers such as arrogance. Notes: counselling helps the person decide and cope. Confidentiality matters; a high-potential label can create loneliness and pressure.
- 7. Rich feedback, including 360-degree if climate allows.** Leadership is seen by subordinates, peers and customers, not only by the boss. Frequent, specific feedback catches derailers early. If culture is not ready for 360, use structured stakeholder comments privately.
- 8. Review, organisational support, honest revision.** A talent council or HRD committee reviews progress yearly. Rewards should recognise development effort, not only last month’s sales. If potential was overestimated, revise the path honestly — specialist excellence is also honourable. If progress is good, the next stretch is offered. This is HRD as a process without a false full stop.

Conclusion. *Propose a multi-year path that uses potential appraisal, career planning, performance goals, stretch jobs, training, mentoring, feedback and counselling together. Leadership potential becomes leadership capability only through an integrated HRD path, not through a title or a single course.*